Anne of a Thousand Days

by Maxwell Anderson

If I die now, I go out into night, and Elizabeth, my firstling, all I have, must face the new world in the morning. To those who die, we seem to go forward into darkness. To those who are newborn, we seem to go forward into dawn. And as I bore Elizabeth, midnight will bear morning.

INTRODUCTION

Anne Bolin has been arrested for a crime she did not commit and has been imprisoned. Her love has also been betrayed. Her crime is adultery and high treason. Her betrayer is her husband, her love, and her king. She was the queen. They called her "Anne of a Thousand Days" by Maxwell Anderson.

If I were to die now, but I must not die yet, not yet. It's been too brief. A few weeks . . . and days. How many days, I wonder, since the first time I gave myself to that last day, when he left me at the lists and I saw him no more? Well I can reckon it. I have time enough. Those who sit in the tower do not lack for time.

He could never cipher. He was shrewd and heavy, and cunning with his tongue, and wary in intrigue. But when it came to adding up an account, he filled it with errors and bit his tongue and swore, till I slapped his hand like a child and took the pen and made it straight. "A king," I said, "a king and cannot reckon."

I was his clever girl then, his Nan. He'd kiss me then, and maul me, and take me down. On the rushes, anywhere. Why do I think of it now? Would he kill me? Kill me? Henry? That fool? That great fool kill me?

Could I kill him, I wonder? I feel it in my hands perhaps I could. So perhaps he could kill me. Perhaps he could kill me. He knew I'd love him when once he'd made me his. And so it was. After that night I loved him more and more, and hated him less and less. And I was lost.

From the first day he made me his, to the last day I made him mine, yes, let me set it down in numbers. I who can count and reckon. Of all the days I was his and did not love him, of all the days I was his and he had ceased to love me? In days…. It comes to a thousand days, out of the years. Strangely, just a thousand. And of that thousand, one… only one when we were both in love, one when our loves met, and overlapped, and were both mine and his. When I no longer hated him, he began to hate me. Except for that one day. One day out of the years.

If his majesty were here….

There are fools and fools, King Henry. You have locked me up here to be tried for adultery and treason towards you. You have done this because you love elsewhere, and I know it. And now you come here, to make sure if there were truly adultery, because that would touch your manhood, or your pride.

And you wait, and listen, a cat in a corner, watching the pet mouse before it dies. And then you come out, to make sure. And oh, fool of fools, even so my heart and my eyes are glad of you. Fool of all women that I am, I am glad of you here.

I never thought what it was like to die. To become meat that rots, and food for shrubs… someone told me the story of the homely daughter of Sir Thomas Moore, climbing at night up the trestles of the London Bridge, where they had stuck her father's head on a spike. And hunting among the stinking and bloody heads, of criminals, still she found her father's head, his beard matted and hard with blood. And climbing down with it and taking it home, to bury in the garden, perhaps.

Would they stick my head up on London Bridge? No even Henry would object to that. I've been his queen! He's kissed my lips. He wouldn't want it. I'll lie in lead, or brass, as meat. Dead meat. But, if my head were on the bridge, he wouldn't climb to take it down. Nobody'd climb for me. I'd stay and face up the river, my long hair blowing out and tangling 'round the spikes. Till the seabirds took me, and there was nothing left but a wisp of hair and a cup of bone.

I must think of something to say, when the time comes. If I could say it, with the ax edge toward me, could I do it? Could I lay my head down, and smile, and speak, till the blow comes? They say it's subtle. It doesn't hurt. There's no time. No time. That's the end of time.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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